general election that year, the Opposition had deprived the BJP of a third consecutive majority, restricting its tally to 240 seats, 32 short of the required mark of 272. And this was despite the pre-poll exit of INDIA's co-founder Nitish Kumar. Now, the Opposition bloc stands reduced to five state governments—Kerala, Karnataka, Telangana, Himachal Pradesh and Jharkhand—along with the National Conference in the Union territory of Jammu and Kashmir. The two powerful regional titans who have fallen, Mamata and Stalin, lost even their own assembly seats—a humiliation piled onto defeat. Both are in their 70s; five years out of power could very well force a generational change. New leadership, in turn, may recalibrate equations within the INDIA bloc. As it stands now, the acronym seems to mock its founders; the real India is overwhelmingly with the NDA.



ANI

BETTER DAYS Rahul Gandhi with M.K. Stalin at an event in Bihar, Aug. 2025

Battle of Perception

Kerala offers some consolation, but it could quickly curdle into complications. The Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) has secured a decisive mandate, with the Congress alone winning 63 of 140 seats and the front crossing the 90 mark. The Left stands humbled; Pinarayi Vijayan's two-term reign is over. Yet the more ominous statistic sits in the BJP column. From zero seats in 2021, the party has won three. This may appear modest, but a similar arithmetic once applied in West Bengal, where the Left had ruled for 34 years. In 2016, Bengal returned three BJP MLAs in a 294-seat assembly on a vote share just above 10 per cent. By 2026, the BJP holds 207 seats with 45.9 per cent of the vote. In Tripura, another former Left bastion, the BJP polled 1.54 per cent and won no seats in 2013; five years later, it formed the government with 36 of 60 seats and a 45 per cent vote share.

Kerala's demography offers familiar contours: a Hindu population of 54 per cent and a Muslim population of 27 per cent—almost identical, in the latter case, to West Bengal and not far from Assam's 34 per cent. These are the very arenas where the BJP's polarisation politics has yielded its richest returns. The conditions for a BJP offensive in Kerala are, therefore, in place. If the Left traces the same arc it did in Bengal and Tripura—and the BJP will work to ensure that it does—the Opposition space in Kerala could be the next prize on the saffron shopping list.

This is the trap the Opposition appears to have wandered into without an exit plan. By default, it reinforces the BJP's framing of the INDIA bloc as a coalition primarily for Muslim voters. In Assam, 18 of the Congress's 19 MLAs are Muslim. So are all three MLAs from the Congress and the Left in the new Bengal assembly. Even within the TMC, 32 of 80 MLAs are Muslim—a 40 per cent share. The reciprocal arithmetic is sharper still: the BJP in both states does not have a single Muslim legislator. For a party that foregrounds religion in its campaigns, this a gift that keeps on giving.

In Tamil Nadu, the Congress has already dumped its long-time ally DMK, prompting the latter to declare it as the end of INDIA

There is a historical irony here that may sting the Congress. After the 2014 Lok Sabha rout, it was a Keralite, A.K. Antony, who had warned that the party needed to counter the perception of favouring Muslims. Twelve years on, the Antony report—intended as a roadmap for revival—gathers dust. Several INDIA bloc constituents face a similar bind. Without a credible effort to broaden their appeal among Hindu voters—or at least to signal such intent—the Opposition will continue to fight elections in which the BJP needs only to consolidate the majority to win.